allegations of corruption against Prime Minister Modi. Implicit in these allegations was the answer to a question being raised across the country: 'Why had the demonetization been announced and implemented in such a hurry, when preparations for such a drastic move were clearly inadequate?'[29]

However, overturning the principle laid down by the SC in the Jain Hawala case, and apparently bringing this controversy to a close, on 11 January 2017, a bench consisting of Justices Arun Mishra and Amitava Roy dismissed the Common Cause petition, stating, 'No democracy can function when allegations are cast against constitutional functionaries without cogent evidence.'

As the 30 December deadline grew nearer, the decisions of the government grew more erratic. In a bizarre move, the RBI issued a circular on 19 December[30] stating that all further deposits would have to be made as a single lump-sum deposit, and that any amount in excess of ₹5,000 would be investigated by two bank officers, who could question the reason for the 'delay' in depositing the money.

People reacted with disbelief and outrage. They felt betrayed, because the Prime Minister and the Finance Minister had personally asked people not to crowd the banks, as they had until 30 December to deposit notes. Faced with a barrage of criticism, the RBI withdrew this circular[31] two days later, on 21 December, albeit only for 'fully KYC compliant accounts'.

The goalposts of demonetization also started getting shifted. Seeing it was not delivering on the goals of eradicating black money, corruption, counterfeit notes and terrorism, the rhetoric began to centre around making India a digital, cashless economy, of widening the tax base, and formalizing the economy.

On 30 December, when the demonetization window closed, everyone hoped that the RBI would finally release some numbers. But, there was complete radio silence. So, when there was an announcement that the Prime Minister would address the nation on 31 December, people eagerly expected a report card of the 50-day